

This might seem like good news for someone who wants to believe in God without arguments. But it leaves us without a real answer to the challenge posed to religious belief by Pastafarianism.

Let's return to the idea of a basic belief you should have. If you think that we should believe that other people are conscious, then it seems like we need to think that there are some basic beliefs you should have of which we cannot be certain and for which we have no sensory evidence. After all, our belief that other people are conscious seems to be (for all we have said) a basic belief you should have.

Here's one idea we might try out. Certain claims just **seem** true to you.

It isn't that you can be certain that they are true, or that have sensory evidence that they are true. They just seem true.

Surely the religious believer should want to say that there is some sense in which their religious belief is reasonable, while Pastafarianism is not.

But they seem to be completely on par. We are conceding (for now) that we have no good arguments for either; but we have no good arguments against the Pastafarian. So what's the difference?

Maybe just the fact that it seems true to us that other people are conscious, and we have no argument against that claim, is good reason for us to believe it. That suggests the following positive rule of belief:

Recall Descartes' worry that if we don't carefully examine our whole structure of belief, we can allow error to slip in. Surely just sticking with our beliefs is not going to be a foolproof way to escape error! So why is Conservatism not just an irresponsibly lazy way to maintain beliefs?

A second response to this is suggested by the following quote from

William James.

Restricted Conservatism

If P is a basic belief you already have, and know of no good argument against P , you should keep believing P .

There are two responses to this. The first is to point out that Restricted Conservatism does not imply that we should not test our beliefs against the evidence. One might believe this principle but be quite ambitious in trying to learn about arguments against one's views.

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I want to look now at three challenges to this kind of rule of belief.

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